FIRST ANGLO-DUTCH WAR

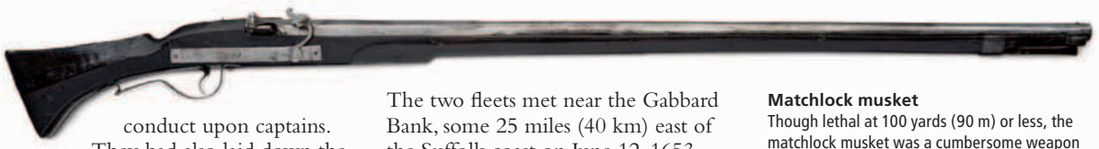
THE GABBARD



Date June 12-13, 1653
Forces English: 110 ships; Dutch: 98 ships
Losses English: none; Dutch: 10 ships sunk, 11 captured

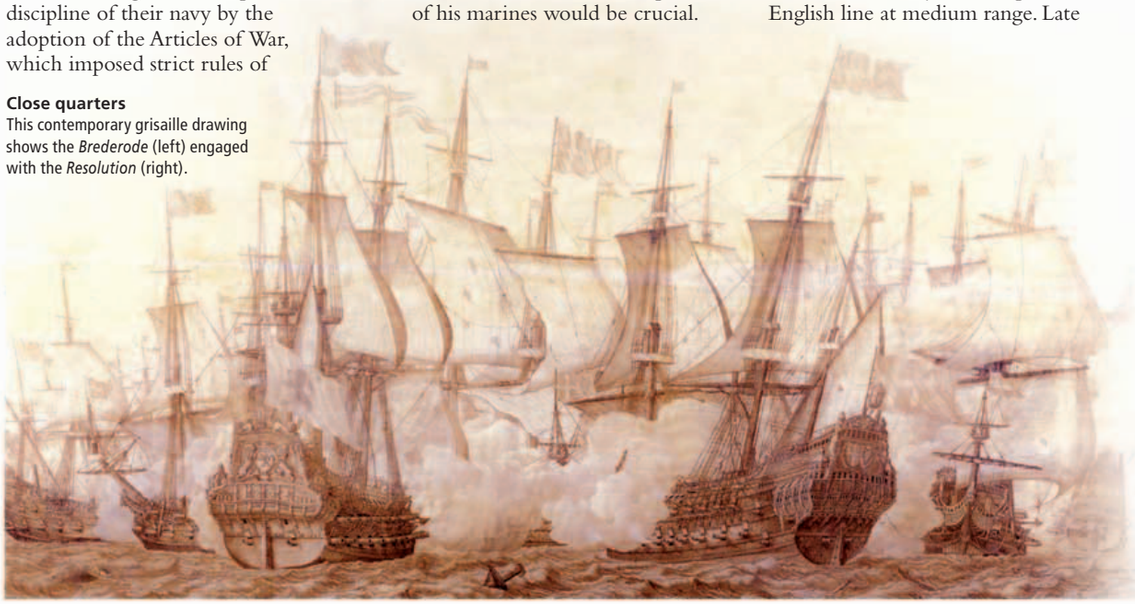
Location Off Suffolk, eastern England

The spring of 1653 found both sides in the Anglo-Dutch War still keen for battle. The English had improved the discipline of their navy by the adoption of the Articles of War, which imposed strict rules of conduct upon captains. They had also laid down the principles of fighting in an orderly line of battle that would maximize the impact of their broadsides. Dutch Admiral Maarten Tromp, however, was still confident that his lighter ships could outmaneuver the English with superior seamanship and force them into a mêlée in which the firepower of his marines would be crucial.



Matchlock musket
Though lethal at 100 yards (90 m) or less, the matchlock musket was a cumbersome weapon that often failed to fire in wet conditions.

The two fleets met near the Gabbard Bank, some 25 miles (40 km) east of the Suffolk coast on June 12, 1653. The battle opened disastrously for the English when one of their two commanding Generals-at-Sea, Richard Deane, was killed by almost the first shot fired. But a light wind made it hard for the Dutch to maneuver and exposed them to steady attrition by broadsides fired by the disciplined English line at medium range. Late in the day Tromp succeeded in trapping part of the English fleet between two of his squadrons, but the balance of damage in the day's fighting was very much in England's favor.



Close quarters
This contemporary grisaille drawing shows the *Brederode* (left) engaged with the *Resolution* (right).

ENGLISH VICTORY

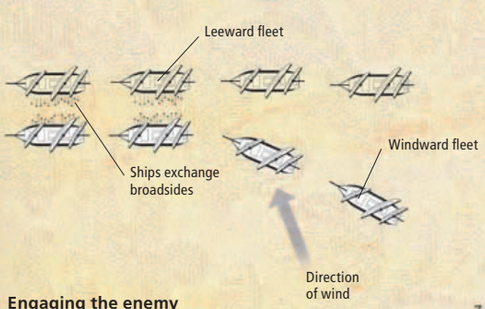
The English fleet was strengthened on the evening of June 12 by the arrival of Admiral Robert Blake with 18 more ships. Tromp nonetheless attacked the next day, which proved unwise. Many Dutch ships were running low on powder and some of Tromp's captains were far keener to escape than to fight. Tromp's flagship *Brederode* was badly holed but avoided capture, its withdrawal covered by the lieutenant admiral's more devoted captains. Eleven Dutch ships were taken by the English, however, and probably as many as 11 destroyed. The survivors found refuge from a pursuing enemy in the shoals off the Dutch coast, where they were put under blockade. Morale on board Tromp's ships was so poor that he did not dare send them into port for repair, for fear of mass desertion. Nonetheless, with trade stopped, Tromp would have to challenge the English again.

MAN-OF-WAR TACTICS

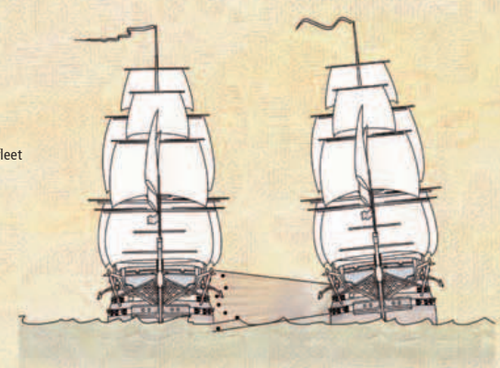
THE LINE OF BATTLE

MAXIMIZING THE USE OF BROADSIDES

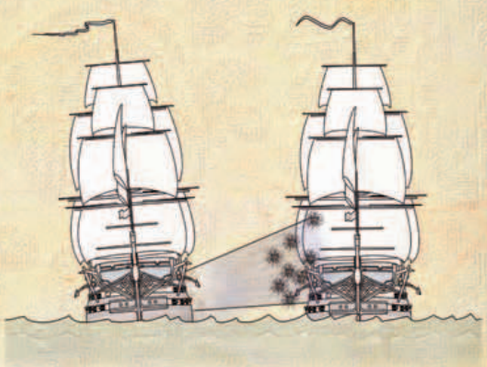
Although casually used on earlier occasions, notably by the Dutch in the prelude to the battle of the Downs in 1639, line-of-battle tactics were first adopted systematically by the English in 1653, during the First Anglo-Dutch War. The line usually consisted of three squadrons, with the senior admiral commanding the center, and vice and rear admirals commanding the van and the rear. It soon became an assumption of naval warfare that both sides would use essentially the same formation. Typically the fleet to windward would approach in line abreast, and then wear together with each ship placing itself alongside an enemy. In a perfect battle, the two lines would sail on the same tack exchanging broadsides, with ships matched to opponents from the lead ship of the van to the rearmost vessel. Only warships from fourth-rate upward were reckoned powerful enough to act as ships of the line. These tactics could be a straitjacket for captains, with more attention focused on keeping alignment than on attacking the enemy. Yet they enabled commanders to keep some control of their fleets and execute coherent maneuvers such as doubling the enemy line if there were spare ships in the van.



Engaging the enemy
The attacking fleet sails from the windward side to attack the enemy. Each ship singles out one of the enemy with which to engage. The windward fleet has many advantages, including being clear of gun smoke, but it cannot easily withdraw.



Firing on the downward roll
This tactic was especially associated with the English. By firing shot into the enemy's hull, they spread death and destruction through the gun decks.



Firing on the upward roll
Some navies preferred directing chain-shot and canister upward to sails and rigging and kill men on the upper decks. The disabled ship would then be open to boarding.